

Multi-Passage Analysis (Synthesis)

A. Navigating Double Passages

When dealing with two passages, the test is evaluating your ability to look at an issue from multiple angles. The relationship between Passage 1 and Passage 2 generally falls into one of these three patterns:

1. Contradictory (Opposing Views): Passage 1 praises a trend, while Passage 2 exposes its dark side or argues against it.
2. Complementary (Supporting Views): Both authors agree on the main premise. Passage 1 might explain the scientific theory, while Passage 2 provides a real-world case study or solution.
3. Supplementary (Different Focuses): Both talk about the same broad topic, but they look at completely different aspects (e.g., Passage 1 discusses the environmental impact of tourism, while Passage 2 discusses its economic benefits).

B. Tactic: The "Cross-Comparison" Method

Do not read both texts blindly from start to finish before looking at the choices.

- Read the introduction of Passage 1 to capture its main stance.
- Immediately read the introduction of Passage 2 to see if the author is smiling (agreeing) or frowning (disagreeing) at Passage 1.
- Watch out for "The Swapped Option Trap": Distractors will frequently attribute an argument to Passage 1 when it was actually stated in Passage 2.

C. Worked-Out Example & Detailed Review

Passage 1 Urban green spaces, such as public parks and botanical gardens, serve as vital infrastructure for fostering mental well-being in densely populated cities. Empirical studies in environmental psychology demonstrate that regular exposure to natural landscapes significantly lowers cortisol levels, a primary physiological marker of stress. Furthermore, these green

sanctuaries offer urban residents a designated space for physical exercise and spontaneous social interactions, which effectively mitigates the profound sense of alienation often experienced in modern metropolitan environments.

Passage 2 While the psychological benefits of urban parks are well-documented, the financial reality of maintaining these green spaces poses a severe dilemma for municipal governments. Allocating scarce public funds to park landscaping and tree maintenance frequently forces cities to cut budgets for essential public services, such as affordable housing and public transportation upgrades. Without a sustainable public-private partnership framework, over-investing in expansive green zones can inadvertently accelerate gentrification, driving up property values and displacing the very low-income residents who need municipal support the most.

Question 1: Which statement best describes the relationship between Passage 1 and Passage 2?

- A. Passage 1 outlines the historical development of urban parks, while Passage 2 predicts their future architectural designs.
- B. Passage 2 completely refutes the psychological findings regarding stress reduction mentioned in Passage 1.
- C. Passage 1 focuses on the health benefits of urban green spaces, whereas Passage 2 highlights the economic and social challenges associated with them.
- D. Passage 2 provides a detailed guide on how to build the public parks described in Passage 1.
- E. Both passages passionately advocate for the immediate expansion of green zones regardless of the financial cost.

- Answer Explanation: Let's break down the core focus of each passage:
 - Passage 1 talks about health and psychology: *"fosters mental well-being"*, *"lowers cortisol levels"*, and *"mitigates alienation"*.
 - Passage 2 acknowledges the benefits but shifts to economics and social issues: *"financial reality poses a severe dilemma"*, *"budget cuts"*, and *"accelerates gentrification"*. Therefore, they are looking at the same topic (urban parks) from

two completely different dimensions (health benefits vs. economic/social challenges). This is perfectly summarized in Option C. Correct Answer: C

D. Independent Practice Task

Passage 1 E-learning platforms have democratized education by breaking down geographical barriers. Students from underprivileged backgrounds can now access world-class lectures from prestigious universities at little to no cost, effectively leveling the academic playing field.

Passage 2 The rapid transition to online education has severely exacerbated the digital divide. Students lacking high-speed internet access or quiet study environments at home are left further behind, turning the promise of virtual learning into an exclusive privilege for the wealthy.

Question: Which of the following best expresses the shared topic but contrasting perspectives of both passages?

- A. Both authors agree that online education is cheaper than traditional schooling.
- B. Passage 1 views e-learning as an equalizer for education, while Passage 2 views it as a source of widening inequality.
- C. Passage 2 suggests a concrete solution to the technical problems mentioned in Passage 1.
- D. Both passages claim that geographic barriers are the most important factor in academic success.
- E. Passage 1 criticizes traditional universities, whereas Passage 2 defends them.